



This thought is the basis of a very famous argument due to Blaise Pascal. Pascal was a 17th century French philosopher, theologian, and mathematician; he made foundational contributions to, among other areas, the early development of the theory of probability.

Pascal was one of the first thinkers to systematically investigate the question of how we should make decisions under situations of uncertainty, where we don't know all of the relevant facts about the world, or the outcomes of our actions. He was (with his contemporary Fermat) the first to formulate the idea of **expected utility**.

Let's turn to our second topic for the day. This is the idea that we should sometimes have a belief for **practical** reasons. If you think about it, forming a belief is just one thing among others that we do. So why wouldn't forming beliefs be governed by the same principles that govern our actions more generally?

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Let's look at one last idea about basic beliefs. This is the idea

Our focus will be a famous argument from Blaise Pascal which

makes use of this idea.



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